people and the nation. What is worse is that people themselves give up on their right to be represented as soon as the ritual of elections is over. The five-year period between two elections is normally seen by them as the period of their ‘civil holiday’. Though these are harsh words, self-blinded citizens and deliberately deaf representatives together have made a mockery of the spirit of the Constitution. India has arrived at this situation, and the means of restoring the spirit of true democracy and the spirit of the Constitution appear to have been sent into a coma during the present regime.

The Bharat Jodo Yatra started waking people up from this coma-like state. Though the media tried its utmost to play it down, thousands and thousands were joining the Yatra voluntarily every day. When it commenced its long march, most predictions were unfavourable, even in circles that did not subscribe to the BJP ideology. But, very soon, the Yatra had gathered great moral capital. People realized that Rahul Gandhi was not what the image-manufacturing machinery of the BJP had made him out to be. At every step of the walk, he came through as an extremely perceptive and yet very humane person, full of care for everyone. A child can climb up on his shoulders and feel comfortable there; an old woman can hold his hand and walk with him in dignity; girls can go up close to him and feel the affection of an elder brother. He has acquired through this entirely public spectacle an image that no amount of propaganda can bring to anyone else. Whether the media and the etherized followers of the right-wing ideology admit it or not, today Rahul Gandhi has become the largest persona, the most spectacular presence in India’s public space. The moral capital that the Yatra generated was deepened by the aesthetics of the Yatra, its optics, its grace and its atmosphere of no hatred.

I saw that a large number of people joining the Yatra consisted of students, workers and farmers. The largest numbers were of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs). Besides, civil society activists who had in the past detested going with the Congress, and writers, artists, singers and filmmakers were participating in the Yatra with unprecedented enthusiasm. The Yatra had generated social capital too. The most significant impact was